The Timing of Early-Life Shocks and Adolescent Mental Health

October 2026

Does the age at which children live through an earthquake affect their mental health?



Shock 27 February 2010 (27-F), magnitude 8.8

Exposed Children aged 0–4

Effects of early-childhood shocks

Birth weight (Torche, 2011)

Cognitive and non-cognitive development (Gillmore, 2026)

Height and learning (Andrabi, Daniels, and Das, 2023)

Adult mental health (Persson and Rossin-Slater, 2018)

This paper

Mental health in adolescence, ages 14–18

▸ PGA map

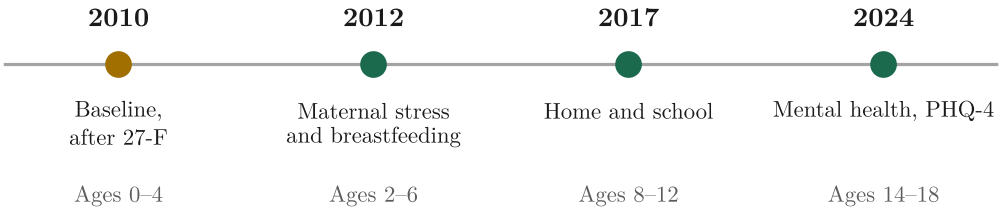
Does it matter at what age children live through the shock?

"The effects of stress on the brain depend critically on the timing (age of onset and duration). When stress occurs early in life it can have profound and lasting effects on brain organization and function." (Gee and Casey, 2015, p. 184)

Potential mechanisms

	Channels
Socioeconomic and family environment	The earthquake reduces income, damages housing, and increases conflict at home (Conger and Donnellan, 2007; Almond, Currie, and Duque, 2018)
Transmission of maternal stress	Infants regulate their stress through the mother. If she is stressed, she passes it on through daily contact (Persson and Rossin-Slater, 2018)

Data



Survey	ELPI, Early Childhood Longitudinal Survey, Chile
Sample	9,996 adolescents born in 2006–2009; 4,961 girls
Respondents	The caregiver in every round; the child in 2017 and 2024

▸ Descriptives

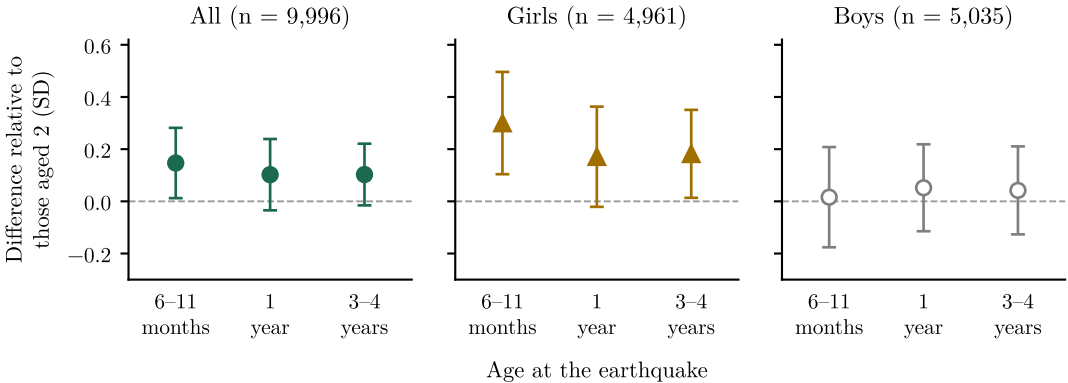
Econometric specification

$$Y_{imc} = \sum_{a \neq 2} \beta_a \left(\text{Age}_{ai} \times \text{Affected}_m \right) + \sum_{a \neq 2} \gamma_a \, \text{Age}_{ai} + \psi_m + \theta_c + X_i' \delta + \varepsilon_{imc}$$

Y_{imc}	Mental health at ages 14–18, PHQ-4
Age_{ai}	Age at the earthquake: 6–11 months, 1 year, or 3–4 years; reference, 2 years
Affected_m	Municipality in the zone of destructive damage
ψ_m, θ_c	Municipality and birth-cohort fixed effects
X_i	Child and household controls

▸ Balance

Effect on mental health

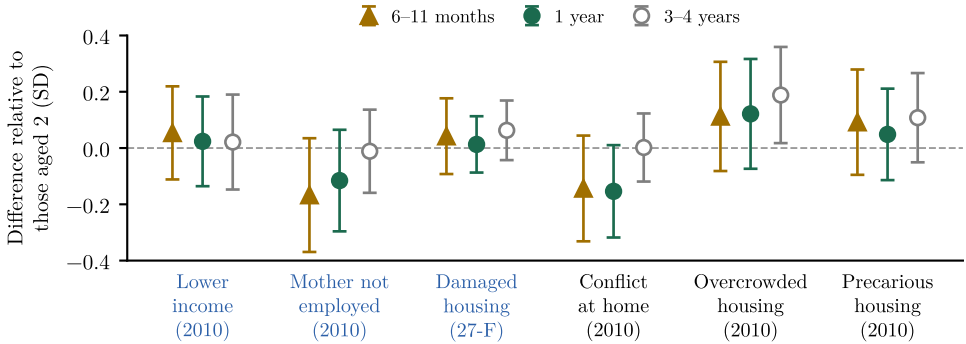


Mental health is measured with the PHQ-4 (Kroenke et al., 2009), four questions answered by the adolescent on symptoms of anxiety and depression (nervousness, worry, loss of interest, and feeling down). Each point is the difference between affected and unaffected municipalities, with 95% CI.

▸ PHQ-4 distribution ▸ Table

Socioeconomic and family environment does not explain the gap

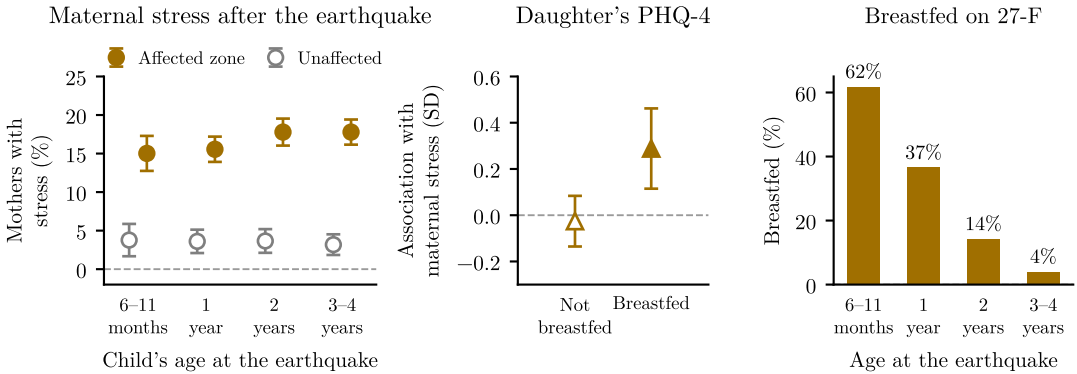
The earthquake worsened the environment (Gillmore, 2026), but with no differences by age



Measured in 2010, one to nine months after the earthquake. In blue, the mechanisms in Gillmore (2026). Lower income, per capita; damaged housing, destroyed or with major damage; conflict at home, the mother shouting, being hostile, or hitting during the visit; overcrowded housing, persons per bedroom; precarious housing, an emergency shack (*mediagua*) or a lent or shared dwelling. Girls, relative to those aged 2; 95% CI.

▸ Table

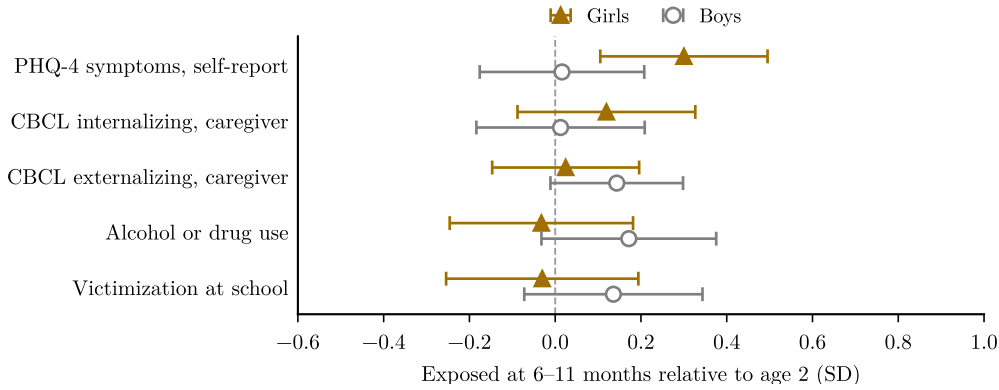
Maternal stress and daughters' mental health by breastfeeding



Active breastfeeding on 27-F serves as a proxy for regulatory dependence and biochemical and behavioral proximity to the mother. Girls, with fixed effects and controls, also for the mother's education and for age; 95% CI.

▸ Table ▸ Means

Among boys, only weak signs in behavior and substance use



▸ Table, girls ▸ Table, boys

Findings

- Girls exposed at 6–11 months have worse mental health than those exposed at age 2, by 0.30 SD on the PHQ-4.
- The socioeconomic and family environment changed similarly at all ages and does not explain this difference.
- Maternal stress is associated with worse mental health only among daughters who were breastfed, 62% of those exposed at 6–11 months.

Open questions

- What explains the effect at ages 3–4, if it operates neither through the socioeconomic and family environment nor through maternal stress?

  Hypothesis: at that age children can already remember consciously what they experience, and the memory of the earthquake could affect their mental health.

References

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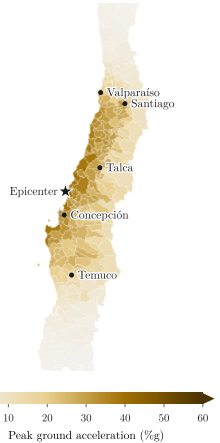
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Figure A1—Peak Ground Acceleration by Municipality



Notes: Peak ground acceleration of the 27-F earthquake, in percent of gravity, at the centroid of each municipality. Affected municipalities in the main specification are those of the six regions with destructive shaking; the map shows how shaking varied within and across them. *Source:* USGS ShakeMap of the event.

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Table A1—Descriptive Statistics

	All		By municipality			
	(1) Mean	(2) SD	(3) Affected	(4) Unaffected	(5) Difference	(6) p-value
Panel A. Adolescent, 2024						
PHQ-4 score (0–12)	4.32	2.68	4.35	4.24	0.10	0.27
PHQ-4 of 6 or more (share)	0.27	0.44	0.27	0.26	0.01	0.33
Girl (share)	0.49	0.50	0.49	0.49	−0.00	0.98
Age at interview (years)	16.76	1.05	16.76	16.74	0.01	0.51
Age at the earthquake (months)	27.06	12.64	27.10	26.93	0.17	0.51
Panel B. Birth and household, 2010						
Birth weight (kg)	3.39	0.50	3.40	3.38	0.01	0.48
Gestation (weeks)	38.64	2.01	38.63	38.67	−0.04	0.59
Mother's age (years)	29.52	7.11	29.68	28.98	0.70	0.00
Mother's education (years)	10.31	3.18	10.31	10.31	−0.00	0.99
Household size	4.93	1.68	4.95	4.86	0.08	0.26
Rural (share)	0.09	0.29	0.09	0.08	0.01	0.68
Panel C. After the earthquake, 2012						
Breastfed on 27-F (share)	0.24	0.43	0.24	0.24	−0.00	0.86
Mother reported stress (share)	0.14	0.34	0.16	0.03	0.13	0.00
Adolescents	10,003		7,654	2,349		

Notes: Means weighted with ELPI sampling weights. Columns 5 and 6: the difference between affected and unaffected municipalities and its p-value, with standard errors clustered by municipality of selection.

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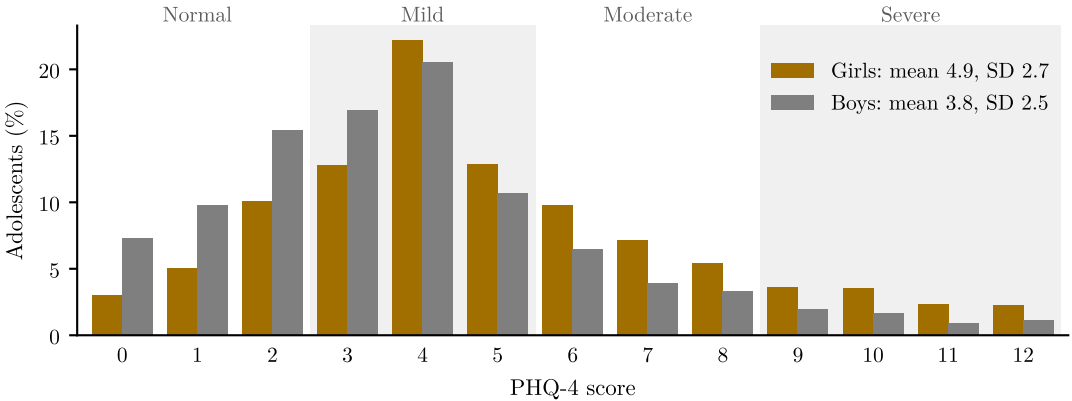
Table A2—Balance on Characteristics Fixed Before the Earthquake

	At birth (SD)			Mother, 2010 (years)	
	(1) Weight	(2) Length	(3) Gestation	(4) Education	(5) Age
6–11 months × Affected	0.193	0.037	0.109	−0.566	−0.121
	(0.118)	(0.096)	(0.111)	(0.333)	(0.775)
1 year × Affected	0.105	0.031	0.096	−0.481	−0.140
	(0.103)	(0.100)	(0.086)	(0.264)	(0.695)
3–4 years × Affected	0.245	0.172	0.182	−0.350	0.457
	(0.083)	(0.099)	(0.075)	(0.300)	(0.603)
Observations	4,530	4,526	4,819	4,883	4,921
Municipality FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Birth-cohort FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Age-group FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Controls	No	No	No	No	No

Notes: Girls. Each column regresses a characteristic fixed before the earthquake on the age group × affected interactions, with municipality, birth-cohort, and age-group fixed effects and no controls. Birth weight, length, and gestation are standardized; the mother's education and age were reported in 2010. Adding the three birth outcomes as controls, the PHQ-4 coefficient for girls exposed at 6–11 months is 0.268 (0.100), against 0.300 (0.100) in Table A3 (4,190 girls with birth records). Standard errors clustered by municipality of selection (116 clusters) in parentheses.

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Figure A2—Distribution of the PHQ-4 Score



Notes: PHQ-4 score in 2024, weighted with ELPI sampling weights. The score adds four items scored 0 to 3; Kroenke et al. (2009) classify 0–2 as normal, 3–5 as mild, 6–8 as moderate, and 9–12 as severe.

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Table A3—Effect on Mental Health

	PHQ-4 (SD)		
	(1) All	(2) Girls	(3) Boys
6–11 months × Affected	0.147	0.300	0.016
	(0.069)	(0.100)	(0.098)
1 year × Affected	0.102	0.171	0.052
	(0.070)	(0.098)	(0.085)
3–4 years × Affected	0.103	0.182	0.042
	(0.060)	(0.086)	(0.086)
Observations	9,996	4,961	5,035
Municipality FE	Yes	Yes	Yes
Birth-cohort FE	Yes	Yes	Yes
Age-group FE	Yes	Yes	Yes
Controls	Yes	Yes	Yes

Notes: The table reports the difference between affected and unaffected municipalities in the PHQ-4 score (standardized) for each age at the earthquake, relative to those aged 2. All regressions include municipality, birth-cohort, and age-group fixed effects and controls for age in months, sex, the mother's age and education, household size, and rural residence (2010), the mother's number of children, and family history of mental illness (2012), and use ELPI sampling weights. Standard errors clustered by municipality of selection (116 clusters) in parentheses.

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Table A4—The Socioeconomic and Family Environment

	Mechanisms in Gillmore (2026), SD			Other household conditions, SD		
	(1) Lower income	(2) Mother not employed	(3) Damaged housing	(4) Conflict at home	(5) Overcrowded housing	(6) Precarious housing
6–11 months × Affected	0.054	−0.167	0.042	−0.144	0.112	0.092
	(0.084)	(0.103)	(0.069)	(0.096)	(0.099)	(0.095)
1 year × Affected	0.024	−0.116	0.013	−0.154	0.121	0.049
	(0.081)	(0.092)	(0.051)	(0.084)	(0.100)	(0.083)
3–4 years × Affected	0.021	−0.011	0.063	0.002	0.188	0.108
	(0.086)	(0.075)	(0.054)	(0.062)	(0.087)	(0.081)
Observations	4,479	4,926	4,424	4,702	4,962	4,961
Municipality FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Birth-cohort FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Age-group FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Controls	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes

Notes: Girls. Each column is a standardized index of the household environment; higher is worse. Measured in 2010, one to nine months after the earthquake, except housing damage, reported in 2012. Lower income, per capita; damaged housing, destroyed or with major damage; conflict at home, the mother shouting, being hostile, or hitting during the visit; overcrowded housing, persons per bedroom; precarious housing, an emergency shack or a lent or shared dwelling. Specification as in Table A3. Standard errors clustered by municipality of selection (116 clusters) in parentheses.

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Table A5—Maternal Stress, Breastfeeding, and Daughters' Mental Health

	Daughters' PHQ-4 (SD)		
	(1) Baseline	(2) Mother's SES	(3) Mother's SES and infancy
Maternal stress × not breastfed	−0.026	−0.005	−0.004
	(0.056)	(0.063)	(0.064)
Maternal stress × breastfed	0.288	0.280	0.286
	(0.089)	(0.096)	(0.112)
Difference, breastfed − not breastfed	0.314	0.285	0.290
	(0.108)	(0.102)	(0.110)
Observations	4,409	4,377	4,377
Municipality FE	Yes	Yes	Yes
Birth-cohort FE	Yes	Yes	Yes
Age-group FE	Yes	Yes	Yes
Age group × breastfed FE	Yes	Yes	Yes
Controls	Yes	Yes	Yes
Stress and breastfed × mother's education and employment	No	Yes	Yes
Stress × 6–11 months	No	No	Yes

Notes: Girls. Maternal stress equals one if the mother reported stress, distress, or anxiety after the earthquake (2012); breastfed equals one if the child was still breastfed on 27-F (2012 report). Column 1 is the estimate in the figure; column 2 lets stress and breastfeeding vary with the mother's education and employment (2010); column 3 also lets stress vary at 6–11 months. Controls and weights as in Table A3. Standard errors clustered by municipality of selection (116 clusters) in parentheses.

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Table A6—Maternal Stress and Breastfeeding by Age at the Earthquake

	Mothers with stress (%)		Breastfed (%)
	(1) Affected	(2) Unaffected	(3) On 27-F
6–11 months	15.0	3.8	61.8
	(1.2)	(1.1)	
1 year	15.6	3.6	36.6
	(0.8)	(0.8)	
2 years	17.8	3.7	14.3
	(0.9)	(0.8)	
3–4 years	17.8	3.2	4.1
	(0.8)	(0.7)	
Children	6,776	2,134	8,880

Notes: Unweighted means, with standard errors in parentheses, by the child's age at the earthquake. Columns 1 and 2 report the share of mothers who reported stress, distress, or anxiety after the earthquake (2012), in affected and unaffected municipalities; column 3, the share of children still breastfed on 27-F.

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Table A7—Other Outcomes, Girls

	Adolescent report (SD)			Caregiver report, CBCL (SD)	
	(1) PHQ-4	(2) Substance use	(3) Victimization	(4) Internalizing	(5) Externalizing
6–11 months × Affected	0.300	−0.032	−0.030	0.119	0.024
	(0.100)	(0.109)	(0.114)	(0.106)	(0.087)
1 year × Affected	0.171	0.026	0.044	0.154	0.100
	(0.098)	(0.096)	(0.081)	(0.120)	(0.107)
3–4 years × Affected	0.182	−0.094	0.081	0.042	−0.082
	(0.086)	(0.083)	(0.092)	(0.095)	(0.083)
Observations	4,961	4,961	4,539	4,748	4,748
Municipality FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Birth-cohort FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Age-group FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Controls	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes

Notes: Girls. Each column is a separate regression with the specification of Table A3. The adolescent reports the PHQ-4, substance use (any alcohol, tobacco, cannabis, or other drug in the last 12 months), and peer victimization and class climate; the caregiver reports internalizing and externalizing problems (CBCL). All measured in 2024 and standardized; higher is worse. Standard errors clustered by municipality of selection (116 clusters) in parentheses.

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Table A8—Other Outcomes, Boys

	Adolescent report (SD)			Caregiver report, CBCL (SD)	
	(1) PHQ-4	(2) Substance use	(3) Victimization	(4) Internalizing	(5) Externalizing
6–11 months × Affected	0.016	0.172	0.136	0.012	0.144
	(0.098)	(0.104)	(0.106)	(0.100)	(0.079)
1 year × Affected	0.052	−0.064	0.112	−0.063	0.053
	(0.085)	(0.089)	(0.086)	(0.099)	(0.092)
3–4 years × Affected	0.042	−0.031	0.098	0.010	0.126
	(0.086)	(0.079)	(0.094)	(0.099)	(0.090)
Observations	5,035	5,034	4,637	4,804	4,804
Municipality FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Birth-cohort FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Age-group FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Controls	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes

Notes: Boys. Outcomes and specification as in Table A7. Standard errors clustered by municipality of selection (116 clusters) in parentheses.

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